

9998

Written by Lawrence Ligad Jr.

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FADE IN:

PROLOGUE

INT. GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NIGHT - YEAR 8122

A CHILD'S HAND folds red paper—one half over the other. A crease becomes a star.

FOUR NOTES sound against hospital glass.

Before the fourth can fade, a FIFTH answers from the receiver—before any living hand moves.

The GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM resolves around the sound—a descending circle carved into black stone. Thousands of faces vanish into the tiers below.

At its center, **DR. ELI MANA**, 38, stands inside a narrow column of white light.

Along the perimeter, sealed ministerial booths illuminate one by one. Documents are signed behind the glass before the discovery has even been announced.

DR. KIRA NIX, 35, watches from the edge of the stage, one hand closed around a palm-sized ceramic device. Four worn pressure surfaces cross its face.

Beside her, **DR. HARP VALE** grips a cracked medical tag engraved: **MARA VALE**.

DIRECTOR ROMAN records which ministers refuse to look afraid.

ELI

We saw a neural signature continue
after death.

Behind him: a scan of a clinically dead brain. Its activity stops. Across the screen, a separate receiving lattice ignites with the same pattern.

ELI

Then it appeared in another living
mind.

Kira's research note materializes beneath his words,
visible only in the stage glass:

PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

ELI

The body died. The pattern didn't.

A minister presses AUTHORIZE. Another acquires exclusive gestation access. A third opens a military channel.

Eli sees none of it. Or chooses the light in front of him.

ELI

We can measure reincarnation.

Kira looks at him. The evidence did not say that. Grief did.

The CHILD'S HAND opens the paper star. The crease remains.

The chamber erupts—applause, prayer, shouting. The sealed booths remain silent. Eli searches for Kira. She meets his eyes but does not move toward him.

Across the room, the first compulsory-access order populates before the applause ends. Harp sees it. Kira sees him see it.

CORRUPTED AUTHENTICATED RECORD - INT. PROJECT REINCARNATION / EXECUTION LAB - LATER THAT NIGHT - YEAR 8122

The applause becomes an EXPLOSION.

Fire folds a laboratory door inward. Cryogenic vapor races along the floor. An alarm keeps repeating one calm sentence: REINCARNATION-AI HUMAN TRIAL COMPLETE.

Dr. Eli Mana crawls through the shattered glass, nearly unrecognizable from the man who stood before the forum. His lab coat is dark with blood. Neural ports have been burned into his skull. Around him, R-AI maps a living mind into light, extracts its continuity pattern and routes it toward a replacement body.

INSERT

REINCARNATION-AI (R-AI) — HUMAN TRIAL

0001 — VOLUNTEER: DR. ELI MANA

RESULT: SUCCESSFUL

INSERT

CLEMENCY EXCHANGE — PRISONER: DR. KIRA
NIX

CONDITION: SUCCESSFUL HUMAN TRIAL

Eli reaches a shattered cryo-pod.

Inside, Kira's body is frozen beneath a skin of white crystal. Her hand is raised against the glass. No vital signs. The state clock on her wrist has stopped at zero.

INSERT

CLEMENCY STATUS: DENIED

INSERT

EXECUTION COMPLETED — SEVEN MINUTES AGO

ELI

You promised.

A security screen clears. Dr. Harp Vale watches from the control room. His face is almost unreadable. Almost.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

They promised clemency if the trial worked.

ELI

It worked. OPEN THE POD!

Harp doesn't move.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

I know.

ELI

OPEN IT!

HARP (ON SCREEN)

She's been dead seven minutes.

A damaged speaker plays the final message recorded inside Kira's pod.

KIRA (RECORDING)

Eli—if they turn return into a prison, break it. Even if I'm in there. If it sounds like me and I tell you to stop... stop.

ELI

I'll find you. Every time.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

No. You won't.

INSERT

ORIGIN MEMORY EXTRACTION — ACTIVE

Light pours from Eli's eyes into the first R-AI lattice. The system separates memory, instinct and identity into transfer-ready data. Kira's name vanishes from his language before her face leaves his heart. He keeps reaching after he forgets why.

A hidden process flickers beneath the extraction architecture.

INSERT

**SEVERANCE — CONTINUITY FIELD SEVERANCE
— PROTOCOL INCOMPLETE**

Before recognition disappears, Eli presses his bloody hand against the pod.

Kira's recording distorts. Four broken tones repeat through the damaged speaker.

Eli answers with one final strike against the glass.

The record tears into white.

The first R-AI lattice divides into thousands of illuminated threads.

Years pass inside the machinery.

8122 – A dying woman opens her eyes inside another body.

8264 – Return becomes a licensed medical procedure.

8511 – The world's continuity archives merge into a single network.

9031 – The CHRONOCRACY absorbs the remaining governments. Their seals disappear beneath its own.

Birth chambers multiply beneath cities. Human lives become numbered state property.

Millions of numbered lives race through the lattice.

9997 - Every thread goes dark.

Then the sequence fractures. The network returns—with something inside it the Chronocracy cannot identify.

SUPER: 1,876 YEARS AFTER ELI MANA'S EXTRACTION

ACT ONE – THE ANOMALY

INT. RETURN CHAMBER - NIGHT - YEAR 9998 – NINE MONTHS AGO

A state-grown adult body hangs upright inside black glass.

KERR, 30s, wakes with no childhood, no family, and no memory of entering the chamber. A stranger's face stares back from every curved reflection.

On his wrist:

KERR – ITERATION 9998. CONTINUITY RECOVERY: INCOMPLETE.
STATE BODY LICENSE: PROVISIONAL.

DR. IMANI VOSS, 40s, a systems engineer whose composure looks practiced rather than natural, watches from behind the glass. A tiny prayer pouch hangs inside her collar—the one private thing she permits the state to see.

Kerr studies his unfamiliar hands.

KERR

Where was I?

IMANI

Nowhere. Not that I could find.

KERR

How long?

Imani looks at the designation on his wrist.

IMANI

Almost nineteen centuries.

Four diagnostic tones sound inside the chamber.

Kerr's hand answers with a fifth knock against the glass.

The chamber goes still.

Far beneath them, the fifth beat enters the buried continuity grid.

Across the foundations of Chronos City, thousands of sealed Return chambers ignite one after another—empty glass holding light for the dead.

Imani's console displays a message no living system should recognize:

ORIGIN LINE – ACKNOWLEDGED

Before she can touch it, the message erases itself. The distant chambers go dark.

KERR

What was that?

IMANI

A fault.

INT. KERR'S STATE APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 9998

SUPER: PRESENT DAY — 274 DAYS AFTER RETURN

Kerr wakes before the state alarm. The apartment is narrow but lived-in: a stubborn green plant, a chipped cup, hand-drawn corrections taped over an official transit map.

His wrist reads KERR — ITERATION 9998. DAY 274. PROVISIONAL CITIZENSHIP. MANDATORY IDENTITY REVIEW 27.

He burns one side of real bread. Four knocks travel through a heating pipe. KERR answers with a fifth before he realizes his hand has moved.

In the window's condensation, his fingertip has traced a woman's eye. He wipes it away.

NEIGHBOR (O.S.)

Review day?

KERR

Twenty-seven. They're still unhappy.

On his way out, KERR leaves a repaired navigation tile beside his neighbor's door. His Mapworks credential pulses with a cancellation: REPORT TO CONTINUITY STABILIZATION.

IMANI waits at the end of the corridor with two cups. She hands Kerr the one without sweetener. He takes it without asking. Nine months have made this a ritual.

IMANI

You ate?

KERR

The bread lost.

They walk toward the review chamber together.

INT. CONTINUITY REVIEW CHAMBER - DAY

Black glass without visible edges. KERR enters through the only door. Every reflection shows him a fraction too late. IMANI takes her place at the manual console.

IMANI

State your designation.

KERR

Kerr. Still.

IMANI

Iteration?

KERR

Nine-nine-nine-eight.

IMANI

Day?

KERR

Two hundred seventy-four. Do I get cake tomorrow?

A sealed record appears beside his reflection: ORIGIN SUBJECT – CLASSIFIED. ARCHIVED PATTERN CORRESPONDENCE: 91.7 PERCENT. ORIGIN CLAIM – UNCLAIMED.

KERR

Still no name.

IMANI

Harp requested a recognition review.

KERR

Nine months. Twenty-seven reviews. What do they want me to say?

IMANI

Recognition. Whoever they think came back.

KERR

And if I recognize him?

IMANI

The state stops calling your origin provisional.

KERR

So you stop asking. You own me.

IMANI

It's both.

KERR

And if I never remember him?

CORE LINK

ORIGIN CLAIM REMAINS UNCLAIMED.

A crack appears across the glass, dividing the classified silhouette from KERR's reflection.

Beyond the observation wall, DIRECTOR ROMAN records the fracture. His face has changed since 8122. He watches with the same stillness.

IMANI

That glass survived the Fracture.

KERR

Did I fail the test?

IMANI

No. That may be the problem.

KERR

I had nine months. I made a life here.

IMANI

Okay. We start there.

INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - LATER

Kerr sits beneath projected civic history. IMANI works at a manual console connected by a sealed hardline to R-AI's Continuity Core beneath Chronos City. R-AI exists only there. Everywhere else, fixed terminals submit narrow requests and repeat its authorized results. The records occupy the wall; Kerr and Imani remain visible beneath them. Recorded voices carry a faint glass resonance. Live voices don't.

INSERT

ARCHIVAL RECORD — SOURCE: CHRONOCRACY

YEAR 8123. The last natural-born human dies. Licensed gestation replaces birth. Spontaneous, unlicensed memory recall is genetically suppressed before the next generation can inherit it.

INSERT

THE GREAT FORGETTING — PEACEFUL
TRANSITION COMPLETE

Kerr watches sleeping children beneath monitors that flag unlicensed neural recall.

YEAR 9785. R-AI scans inherited patterns and identifies 3,104,881 people statistically likely to rebel.

INSERT

THE SILENT UPRISING — ZERO CIVIC
CASUALTIES

YEAR 9997. A woman inside a state scanner linked to the central R-AI core opens twelve contradictory lives at once. The prediction system physically fractures.

INSERT
NULL-PATTERN SUBJECT – TWELFTH
RECORDED DEATH

For three seconds, the entire network fails. In those three seconds, an unassigned host in the Continuity Reserve awakens without a continuity pattern.

INSERT
UNINDEXED HOST V-16 – CLASSIFIED

KERR
Who is she?

IMANI
The record won't say.

Kerr's breath catches. His fingertips press four shallow dents into the arm of the chair. He looks back at the woman frozen inside the corrupted record.

Imani rolls a calibration tray between them. Three objects sit beneath white light: a cracked lens, a laboratory seal with its name burned away, and a battered analog sketchbook. The book came from the sealed origin archive. Its identifying marks have been removed. Equations survive on the first pages. The rest appear blank. Kerr touches the laboratory seal. Nothing. The cracked lens. Nothing.

His thumb catches on the sketchbook's cloth cover.

KERR
Take it.

Imani reaches for the book. She opens it to a blank page. Faint pressure grooves cross the paper—marks left by hands.

Kerr drags the side of a graphite stick across the page, trying to expose the grooves. A woman's eyes emerge.

He stops.

His hand moves again. New lines cut across clean paper: a girl beneath Earth repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

KERR
That wasn't in the paper.

The ceiling camera tightens focus.

Imani drops a calibration slate over the page and tags the event INVOLUNTARY MOTOR ARTIFACT – INCONCLUSIVE.

Kerr looks from the false tag to Imani. She leaves the sketchbook within his reach.

Imani turns back to the console.

**INTERCUT - INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR
- NIGHT**

An unassigned sixteen-year-old host wakes among thousands of preserved bodies. Condensation and frost conceal her face. Before the monitoring lead can register consciousness, she tears it from her chest.

In the Stabilization Suite, the ceiling camera extracts the unknown girl's face from Kerr's drawing and searches the Continuity Reserve inventory.

INSERT

POSSIBLE BIOMETRIC
CORRESPONDENCE — HOST V-16

IDENTITY: UNASSIGNED

The system begins resolving V-16's location.

UNINDEXED HOST LOCATION
RESOLVING

Kerr sees the preserved bodies entering the search field. He drives his thumb into the origin port embedded beneath his wrist nine months ago.

IMANI

If you break that claim, the state
will classify you as hostile
continuity.

KERR

It's using me to find her.

He tears the port free. Blood crosses the classified silhouette. The location collapses one meter before reaching V-16.

INSERT

ORIGIN AUTHENTICATION —
CORRUPTED

Every door in Chronos City locks. His apartment access, Mapworks credential, and provisional citizenship vanish in succession. Nine months of life become three red words: HOSTILE CONTINUITY — REVOKED.

In the Continuity Reserve, the unidentified figure studies five marks in the condensation beside her—four together, one apart. Frost keeps her face unreadable.

Every clock in the suite blanks. A new number appears across the glass.

SEVERANCE AUTHORIZED — HARP VALE

ORIGIN-LAYER CONVERGENCE — 72:00:00

KERR

What did she wake up?

IMANI

A purge clock.

KERR

How long?

IMANI

Seventy-two hours.

KERR

Until what?

Imani looks toward the dark camera in the ceiling.

IMANI

Harp is routing every mind waiting for a body into one place.

KERR

Why?

IMANI

V-16 gave him cover. He started Severance. At zero, every other route shuts.

KERR

What happens to the people waiting?

Imani doesn't answer.

KERR

Imani.

IMANI

He saves one return path. His.

KERR

His?

IMANI

Your living choice is the key.

The purge clock begins to fall: 71:59:42.

The recorded voices cut out. The history projection vanishes, returning us fully to Kerr and Imani. Four symbols remain: a closed circle, a broken circle, a black square, and a gold spiral. Only the first three receive labels.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Captured record. Reconstructed memory.
Sealed record.

KERR

Which one is real?

IMANI

One was captured. One rebuilt. One hidden.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Authenticated record selected.
Personal history. Year 8119.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - PERSONAL HISTORY - INT. FAMILY
APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 8119**

Ordinary sunlight. Kira burns toast. Eight-year-old SID MANA-NIX draws constellations on the ceiling with a toy projector. One front tooth is missing. She folds two pieces of red paper and locks them together into a star.

KIRA

You used two pieces.

SID

If one gets lost, the other still keeps the folds.

ELI

Paper doesn't remember.

SID

Then why's the crease still there?
Checkmate, paper.

Eli starts to answer, realizes he has been outmaneuvered by an eight-year-old.

SID

Four notes means, "Are you still there?"

Kira taps four notes on a glass. SID answers with a bright fifth.

KIRA

And that means?

SID

"I heard you."

ELI

That's not how information theory works.

SID

You came in from the other room, right? So it worked. You're welcome.

KIRA

Peer review is devastating at this age.

ELI

One subject, no control group. Brutal methodology.

SID

I control both of you. Tiny sample, huge power.

Eli laughs.

The record advances. Before R-AI, Eli's receiver is an assistive neural-audio translator built to translate SID's failing speech. Sid sits beneath handmade sensors while Kira tunes brain activity into sound. Eli writes the receiver. Harp installs a consent gate. Years later, the state will build Reincarnation-AI around this architecture.

HARP

It can't initiate contact, retain a response, or identify a speaker without permission.

SID

Good. What happens if I change my mind after I say yes?

HARP

Then it stops and deletes the session.

SID

Even if Dad says it's important?

HARP

Especially then.

ELI

You understand all that?

SID

Adults use long words when they're scared. Uncle Harp makes rules.

HARP

Someone in this family should.

Kira presses the first RESONANCE KEY against the glass and touches its four ceramic surfaces. The prototype carries the notes through the bed frame. Sid's neural response returns as the FIFTH.

SID

It remembered me.

ELI

It translated a repeatable neural pattern. Remembering would imply an internal experience we haven't established.

SID

That's a very long way to say yes.

KIRA

She has you there.

Sid asks the prototype to delete the session. Harp activates the consent gate. The screen clears.

The FIFTH NOTE sounds a fraction of a second before Sid's brain produces it.

ELI

Prediction artifact. Weird one, but still...

KIRA

Or feedback from a system we don't understand yet.

ELI

It answered first.

HARP

Log the timing. No theory.

On the blank screen, four words appear without a prompt: I HEARD YOU BEFORE.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - YEAR 9998

Kerr returns with Sid's two-piece red paper star drawn in the sketchbook margin. He has drawn the interlocking crease without being shown it—and older pressure grooves beneath his fresh lines follow the same fold.

KERR

Sid.

IMANI

The girl's name was Sid. The other identities are sealed.

KERR

That was his memory, right?

IMANI

You can inherit a feeling. It still isn't yours.

The authenticated image destabilizes. Rain replaces the apartment sunlight.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Unstable recall detected. Source confidence: indeterminate.

UNSTABLE RECALL - INT. DR. ELARA'S OFFICE - DAY (8121)

Rain on old glass. No screens. Kerr experiences the scene through the sealed patient's eyes. DR. ELARA, 44, trauma psychologist, watches him turn Sid's red paper star. The patient's face glitches in reflection.

ELARA

You have explained quantum persistence for forty minutes.

ELI

You asked what I believe happens after death. I'm trying to answer carefully.

ELARA

Forty minutes, Eli. What do you miss?

Eli looks at the star.

ELI

She'd try to hold in a laugh, but the gap in her teeth made it whistle. Then she'd laugh harder because I noticed.

ELI

I don't know how to believe what I can't measure.

ELI

If the signal's there, maybe the receiver is wrong. I can fix it—

ELARA

Maybe. But a signal isn't automatically Sid. You know that.

Elara writes three statements on paper.

INSERT

EVERY RETRIEVAL MAY ALTER A MEMORY.

INSERT

BUT IT IS NOT NOTHING.

Elara takes the paper star from him, opens it, then gives it back unfolded.

ELARA

Look at the star. You folded it until it tore. Say her name.

The office repeats. Rain reverses. The sealed patient disappears; present-day Kerr replaces him in the chair, holding the star. Elara's face becomes R-AI's civic mask, then Elara again.

KERR

Are you Elara or a reconstruction?

ELARA

You're asking me. Not her.

KERR

Then why am I seeing this?

ELARA

I don't know. But you brought the same star.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - YEAR 9998

Kerr returns with the red star drawn across three sketchbook pages. Folded together, their disconnected margins form the same woman's eyes.

KERR

Was that authenticated?

IMANI

No. The system reconstructed Elara from the sealed patient's therapy records, recorded sessions and your present cognition.

KERR

So she never said those words.

IMANI

Some were hers. Some were yours. The system can't separate them now.

KERR

Then why show me?

KERR

You could've mentioned that before the dead woman started reading my mind.

MEMORY CONSOLE

The Chronocracy found the distinction politically inefficient.

IMANI

That means yes. She could have warned you.

The door opens. Harp heard the last sentence.

INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - NIGHT

HIGH REGENT HARP VALE enters alone. His elegant twelfth body appears no older than thirty. Twelve renewal dates shimmer beneath his wrist.

HARP

You always wake angry.

KERR

Were you always there when I woke?

HARP

The important ones. Sometimes you wanted water. Sometimes you tried to kill me before you could stand. Once... you apologized for not knowing me.

KERR

Which one did you prefer?

HARP

The one who asked why.

KERR

Imani said you need me to open something.

HARP

The Origin Core.

KERR

And what do you need from me?

HARP

A living claimant has to choose access.

KERR

Then why keep calling me Eli?

HARP

Because Eli's authority is the only claim the state recognizes.

KERR

And if I don't give it to you?

HARP

Then the state will put you at the gate until you choose.

KERR

So this review is a threat.

HARP

You can say yes before it comes to that.

Harp gestures. The purge clock expands across the wall.

HARP

At zero, every waiting mind goes to one destination. The other routes close.

KERR

Protected where?

HARP

Me.

KERR

Everybody disappears. You stay.

For the first time, Harp looks his age.

Harp studies Kerr's sketchbook. Separate pages overlap: the woman's eyes, four notes and fragments of corridor geometry.

HARP

Every body drew fragments. Yours finally made a whole face. Twelve recorded deaths, probably hundreds more, and she is the first thing R-AI cannot predict.

INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - MINUTES LATER

Imani unlocks Kerr's room with an analog override braided into the cord of her prayer pouch. The panel requests authorization. She enters the same SENSOR NOISE code she used to delay Kerr's report. The lock accepts before she finishes. Imani freezes. A corridor camera pivots from Imani to Kerr. Its facial lock climbs toward one hundred percent; Kerr's wrist flashes ORIGIN CLAIMANT, then DEFECTIVE RETURN. COMMANDER SATO, 50s, a veteran Enforcer whose loyalty implant has outlived three bodies, waits beneath it with a weapon and a battered mechanical watch.

KERR

And you are?

SATO

Right now? The man not pointing this at you.

Sato sees DEFECTIVE RETURN. His thumb presses the watch crown as if stopping an old reflex. Then he shoots the corridor camera before facial lock completes. The red upload light dies. A state notice flashes through the smoke: FEED LOST – NEAREST ENFORCER NEURAL RELAY IN 00:00:40. The countdown binds the broken camera to Sato's loyalty implant.

SATO

Forty seconds before the implant changes my mind. Move.

IMANI

That override shouldn't have worked. Why are you opening the door?

SATO

The last person I brought through here was my daughter. They said there wasn't enough left. I signed the report.

SATO

Then it showed me tomorrow. Clean streets. Trains on time. Nobody out of line.

IMANI

If we leave this room, where are you going?

KERR

The woman in the record. I need to know why Harp buried her. After that... I don't know. I just need out of this room.

IMANI

Not much of a route. Better than standing here.

They run.

INT. TRANSIT SPINE - NIGHT

Enforcers close from both ends. The corridor predicts their movement in red light before they make it.

IMANI

Move. Now.

KERR

You just told me not to decide.

IMANI

I changed my mind. Move.

Kerr flips open the sketchbook. A line drawn in the chamber matches the corridor's red prediction path. He steps left, remembers dying left, spins right. A drone fires where his intention had been.

SATO

Down. Now.

He opens an emergency hatch. They plunge.

EXT. CHRONOS CITY - NIGHT

They emerge onto a transit spine suspended in the fog above CHRONOS CITY.

One black tower rises beside them and disappears into weather before its upper floors become visible. Another is

only a shadow across the fog. No traffic noise. No voices carry between them.

Transparent freight capsules pass overhead. A sleeping adult body fills each one. Far below, a renewal queue folds through the same plaza again and again; Kerr cannot see where it begins.

Citizens cross a plaza large enough for an army. Their former lives appear only when the state recognizes them. Expiration dates burn beneath their wrists like social rank.

A CHILD steps outside her assigned lane. The paving stone lights red. Her mother returns her to the line before an Enforcer turns around.

The seventy-two-hour purge countdown stains the low cloud above the plaza.

A civic lesson repeats: LIFE ALLOCATION. BODY TERM CLAIMANT. MEMORY PROVEN. RETURN PRESERVATION.

KERR

The Chronocracy?

IMANI

The state picks your body. It edits what doesn't fit. It even tells you when to die.

KERR

Who chose Harp?

SATO

The first generation.

Every camera turns toward Kerr. A municipal speaker wakes. Its vocabulary is limited to enforcement commands.

CIVIC SECURITY

RETURN TO CARE, ORIGIN CLAIMANT.

KERR

KERR.

CIVIC SECURITY

SELF-DESIGNATION CORRECTION REGISTERED.

KERR

Can R-AI hear me?

CIVIC SECURITY

REPORT TO CARE.

KERR

That was not an answer.

IMANI

R-AI isn't in that speaker. It's under the city. This thing only repeats orders.

For less than a frame, an encrypted audit header flickers beneath the civic feed. The terminal can't open it. Kerr sees only the Core's refusal code because his return is still out of calibration.

INSERT

CENTRAL R-AI AUDIT LOG 07 — REMOTE
REQUEST DENIED

INSERT

CORE ITERATION 0043 — ANOMALOUS MEMORY
RESILIENCE

INSERT

RECOMMENDATION: OBSERVE. Don't
INTERVENE.

INSERT

ADDENDUM: CONTRADICTION REGISTERED.

INSERT

AUDIT REVIEW REQUIRED. DISCLOSURE
PROHIBITED.

Imani sees the contradictory orders before the municipal terminal restores its blank enforcement screen.

For one frame, every civic screen shows the silhouette of a girl drawing Earth repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

A FIFTH NOTE escapes every municipal speaker before the next security command arrives. A dark spiral turns beneath Kerr's reflection. The city audio cuts out.

CIVIC SECURITY

UNINDEXED HOST SEARCH ACTIVE.

The cameras turn away.

EXT. TEMPLE OF RETURN - NIGHT

They descend into a temple filled with shallow black water. Families wait on isolated platforms beneath queue numbers. Ministers pray. Clerks calculate. No one acknowledges the difference.

A WOMAN holds her dying husband on one platform. A young replacement body sleeps on another, fifty meters away. The state gives the family thirty seconds to prove sufficient continuity.

WOMAN

Will he remember me?

MINISTER

If the bond served continuity.

WOMAN

I asked whether he'll know my face.

The replacement body's eyes open. Across the water, the husband's wrist advances from twelve minutes to three seconds. His wife sees both bodies and can reach neither.

At zero, his first body falls into the water. The replacement sits up before the splash reaches the platform.

The clerk removes the dead man's number from the queue. The next family is called.

The WOMAN looks from the body in the water to the awakened stranger. The date on her husband's wrist goes dark.

MINISTER

He has entered lawful return.

INT. ANALOG ZONE - NIGHT

The corridor narrows until the city can no longer stand upright around them. Electric light gives way to candles. Low ceilings sweat. Pipes carry repairs from five different centuries. Shoes wait outside curtained rooms. Food passes through a hatch. Somewhere beyond the walls, someone misses a note and starts the song again. No system hum tells them what the room expects.

A MASKED WOMAN steps from the candlelight. A cracked ceramic RESONANCE KEY rests in her palm, small enough to disappear. Kerr's sketchbook falls open. The eyes he drew in the chamber stare back from the page—and from above her mask.

KERR

I've been drawing your eyes.

MASKED WOMAN

You've been drawing somebody. You haven't met me.

MASKED WOMAN

First tell me why your book knows this place.

KERR

I don't know. Every time I remember something, the drawings get less wrong.

She takes the sketchbook without touching him.

She flips past the sealed equations, Sid's folded star and the woman's eyes. Across several pages, stray lines join into a route through the Analog Zone.

KERR

Those lines were there before I left the chamber.

MASKED WOMAN

And now they map my home. Cute. Also terrifying.

She keeps her mask on and leads them deeper. At every junction, the sketchbook route matches the architecture a moment before Kerr sees it.

MASKED WOMAN

Follow me.

KERR

What if it brought me to you?

MASKED WOMAN

Then it made a mistake.

KERR

You recognized me.

MASKED WOMAN

I recognized something.

KERR

What?

Kerr tries not to smile. The left corner of his mouth lifts.

The Masked Woman goes still.

MASKED WOMAN

That.

KERR

My mouth?

MASKED WOMAN

You always did that when you knew someone was lying.

KERR

How many times have you seen me?

At the final turn, the newest sketch aligns with the room around them.

The Masked Woman studies the completed portrait, then removes her mask. It's the face Kerr's hand has been approaching page by page.

KIRA

My name is Kira.

KERR

The woman from the Fracture?

KIRA

The body from the Fracture.

KERR

I watched you die.

KIRA

Then you saw what happened.

KERR

How are you standing here?

KIRA

The network failed. I woke up in a body nobody claimed. The old consent lock must've thrown me somewhere blind.

KERR

Is it really you?

KIRA

I don't know. Some days I remember dying. Some days it happened to someone else.

KERR

Why keep the name?

KIRA

I didn't get to choose much. I chose the name.

KERR

Does Harp know?

KIRA

He knows the versions in his files. He doesn't know me.

She steps closer, allowing him to see the unfamiliar details of her face.

KIRA

He hasn't met this one. I'm not dying for him again.

KERR

The forced Returns—or all of it?

KIRA

All of it. Harp can't follow me into the Continuity Field. So I'm going there.

KIRA

Twelve times I wake up and somebody hands me a debt. No more.

KERR

And everyone else's soul?

Kira looks toward the people sheltering in the next room.

KIRA

Not my decision. Ask them.

INT. ANALOG ZONE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT

Kira leads them past curtained rooms carved beneath the city. Hands repair clocks at one doorway. A child copies letters at another. Music travels through the pipes, stops on a wrong note, then begins again.

A mural lists the rights forbidden above: THE RIGHT TO FORGET. THE RIGHT TO REFUSE RETURN. THE RIGHT TO CHANGE WITHOUT EXPLANATION.

KERR

How many people live here?

KIRA

Six hundred twelve. Roughly. People come and go. Drives Harp insane.

A return alarm sounds inside a side room. Kira enters. Kerr follows.

LENA, 30s, wakes in an illegal body. DANE, 60s, waits beside her holding a wedding photograph. Lena studies him without recognition.

DANE

You came back.

LENA

Who are you?

Dane reaches for her. Kira catches his wrist before contact.

KIRA

Ask.

DANE

She's my wife.

KIRA

She died. This woman just woke up.
Don't touch her.

Dane's hope turns defensive.

DANE

We had forty-three years.

LENA

I'm sorry. I know I'm hurting you. I
just... I don't know you.

DANE

You didn't do anything. You're
disoriented. It'll come back when the
transfer settles.

KIRA

Dane. Take your hand off her.

Kerr watches Dane keep his distance.

Dane lowers his hand.

DANE

My name is Dane. I knew someone who
looked like you before she died.

LENA

Did you love her?

DANE

Very much. We were terrible before
breakfast.

LENA

Was she kind?

DANE

Sometimes. Not always. But she tried.

A small smile reaches Lena without memory.

DANE

May I sit here?

LENA

Yes.

He sits at a distance and turns the wedding photograph face
down.

LENA

You can leave it up.

DANE

Only if you want it. I shouldn't have
come at you like that.

Kira exits. Kerr follows her into the corridor.

KERR

How often does this happen?

KIRA

Enough that the state gave her seventy-two hours to remember him.

KERR

And if she doesn't?

KIRA

They take her body.

KERR

Dane knew that?

KIRA

He helped us steal it.

They look back. Dane remains where Lena left him. He does not follow her.

KERR

What happens now?

KIRA

He gives her time.

KERR

Is that what you're doing with me?

KIRA

I'm trying.

KERR

That isn't an answer.

KIRA

It's the one I have.

They pass a classroom. Children draw people and places absent from every licensed record.

IMANI watches a girl erase a woman from her drawing, then put her back.

IMANI

My mother refused another body.

KERR

You understood?

IMANI

No. I called her selfish.

KERR

Were you wrong?

IMANI

I wanted her back. I told her she was selfish.

An Analog musician loses the melody, curses under his breath and starts again.

INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - LATER

A cramped kitchen assembled from scavenged centuries.

Kira burns toast over a heating coil. Kerr reaches across her and kills the heat before the alarm sounds.

KIRA

You always did that.

KERR

Burn the toast?

KIRA

Notice two seconds too late.

KERR

That sounds more believable.

KIRA

You don't know yourself well enough to call me a liar yet.

The remark lands harder than she intended.

On the wall: Kira's folded half of Sid's red paper star, a map beneath the capital and four memory symbols.

Kerr points to the gold spiral.

KERR

What's that one?

KIRA

A pre-echo. A memory recorded before the event that caused it.

KERR

The girl beneath the black sun.

Kira turns to him.

KIRA

Where did you hear that?

KERR

I didn't.

He opens the sketchbook. The repeated drawing stares up at them.

KERR

I've been drawing her since I woke up.

Kira takes the book. For the first time, Kerr sees her genuinely frightened.

KERR

Is she real?

KIRA

There's one record like this. We never found the person in it.

KERR

But Harp tried.

KIRA

He's still trying.

She opens the map. A route descends beneath the capital toward the Continuity Core.

KIRA

Harp can read everything R-AI kept. He still can't open the Origin Core.

KERR

Why not?

KIRA

Every archived Eli failed. The Core wants somebody alive to say yes.

Kerr looks at the route ending beneath the city.

KERR

Me.

KIRA

Harp needs you to choose inside the Core.

KERR

What do you believe?

KIRA

If Harp had the answer, we'd be dead.

She marks one symbol: ORIGIN. Beneath it, the state has written: LIVING CLAIMANT – UNCONFIRMED.

IMANI

V-16.

KIRA

The unassigned host from the Fracture. If she's alive, Harp doesn't know what she is either.

KERR

You want to use her against him.

KIRA

I want to reach her first. Then we ask.

Kira draws a route from the Continuity Reserve to R-AI's Origin Core, then circles the falling purge clock.

KIRA

We get V-16 out. If she comes with us,
Kerr opens the Core and we find out
what happened during the Fracture.

KERR

And if we fail?

IMANI

Everyone waiting to return is erased.
Harp is all that remains.

They study the route. Beyond the rescue point, the map is blank.

INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - NIGHT

Kerr touches Kira's half of the red paper star. His hand trembles. He pulls it back.

KERR

Who was he?

KIRA

Someone I loved. See what he did first.

KERR

Harp thinks he is inside me.

KIRA

Harp needs your body to make an old
record legal. He doesn't know you.

KERR

Then let's get there before he puts
another name on me.

KIRA

What if it feels like yours?

KERR

Fine. But I decide.

Kira places the resonance key in his
palm and closes his fingers around it.
She does not give him her hand.

Every mechanical clock in the safe-house stops at once. The candle flames lean toward the walls as the state grid finds the room. On Kira's map, every marked exit turns red. The maintenance trench beneath them stays dark.

CIVIC SECURITY (V.O.)

Analog Zone coordinates resolved.
Sanctuary purge authorized.

Stone shutters slam down. Above them, Enforcer charges strike the street.

SATO

Well. Decision made. Safe route's gone.

Kira pulls an emergency lever. The unmarked floor drops beneath Kerr, Kira, Imani and Sato, spilling them into the maintenance trench as the safe-house folds into fire overhead.

The shaft seals behind them. There is no way back to the life Kerr spent nine months building.

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ACT TWO — THE CLAIM

INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - NIGHT

Five preservation chambers face them through the frost. Their reflections repeat down both walls until the aisle appears endless. Emergency light sweeps past: five adult faces, then darkness. Cooling locks release one after another far beyond the visible sector.

KERR, KIRA, IMANI and SATO move through a maintenance trench beneath the sector. The citywide purge clock reads 61:36:09.

IMANI

Every chamber reports directly to the Continuity Core. If the hardline reconnects, Harp sees us.

KERR

How long do we have?

IMANI

I cut the local relay. It could stay down for a minute. It could be back already.

Kira presses the resonance key to a coolant pipe and touches its four worn surfaces. The notes pass through metal rather than air.

RESERVE CONTROL

Unresolved consent claim. State procedure suspended.

The scanners stop moving. Imani watches a dead status light that can wake without warning.

They climb into the sector.

**INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR -
CONTINUOUS**

The chamber marked V-16 is open. Its display still reports an occupied body and a steady heartbeat. Sector search lights continue scanning the empty glass.

Wet footprints cross the floor. A state wrist band lies split beside an exposed maintenance panel. Someone has stripped wire from the wall and built a release tool from it.

Sato raises his weapon.

A restraint cable snaps tight around his throat from behind. **VEYRIS**, sixteen in body and one year awake, holds the other end. Medical ports have been torn from her skin. Her stance is balanced. Her eyes move across all four intruders, measuring which one she will have to hurt first.

VEYRIS

Put it down.

Sato lowers the weapon. Veyris keeps the cable tight.

KIRA

We didn't come to kill you.

VEYRIS

You came through a locked door.

Kerr's sketchbook slips from beneath his coat and falls open. Veyris sees her face on the page.

The cable tightens.

VEYRIS

Where did you get that?

KERR

I drew it.

VEYRIS

Harp has the same picture.

KERR

Did he tell you where it came from?

VEYRIS

He thought I did.

KIRA

What's your name?

VEYRIS

Veyris.

IMANI

V-16 activated during the Fracture. No assigned continuity. No registered claimant.

VEYRIS

Their records aren't my problem.

A surveillance lens above them quietly rotates. Veyris sees it first.

She releases Sato, drives the metal tool through the lens and tears open the maintenance panel.

VEYRIS

They know you're here.

KIRA

Then come with us.

VEYRIS

I'm leaving. You can keep up.

The far doors unlock. Enforcers enter from both ends of the sector.

INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - CONTINUOUS

KIRA meets the first Enforcer before his weapon clears its holster. Sato turns on his former unit. Veyris moves toward the maintenance route she has already opened.

An Enforcer catches Veyris by the wrist.

She turns into his grip instead of pulling away, drives the metal release tool beneath the seal of his weapon hand and twists.

The weapon discharges into the floor. Veyris tears free and slams him against a preservation chamber. Before he can recover, she rips the state band from his wrist and throws it between the closing doors.

The security system follows his signal into the wrong corridor.

They reach the sealed maintenance gate.

SATO

Your route ends here.

Veyris opens the control housing. A strip of wire is already bridging two contacts.

She drives the release tool into a third contact. The lock resists.

Kira sees the manual pressure valve beside the frame and forces it down. The gate releases hard enough to shake the corridor.

Veyris leads them through.

INT. ANALOG MAINTENANCE SKIFF - NIGHT

An obsolete rail skiff carries them beneath the city without a network connection. Its wheels strike imperfect intervals. VEYRIS sits beside the open service window, feeling unfiltered rain for the first time.

VEYRIS

It hurts.

IMANI

It's called being cold. Your skin will decide whether it hates it after the surprise wears off.

VEYRIS

The facility called weather an infrastructure failure.

SATO

Warm. Fed. Quiet. Wanting was the dangerous part.

VEYRIS

Is it beautiful?

IMANI

Not when it gets inside your underwear.

Imani wraps a coat around Veyris.

Kira watches the city recede. Kerr watches Kira pretending not to watch him. Then hits him for noticing.

VEYRIS

Why did she hit you?

KERR

Apparently I arrived late.

VEYRIS

How late?

KERR

About two thousand years.

VEYRIS

Then she held back.

Sato almost laughs. Kira doesn't hide hers.

SKIFF DIAGNOSTIC

SIGNAL SOURCE: UNRESOLVED.

SATO

None of us knows what we're doing.
You'll fit right in.

Ahead, the rail terminates at a decommissioned R-AI transfer conduit. State searchlights sweep into the tunnel behind them.

Sato jumps from the skiff and forces open a service hatch.

SATO

This line was disconnected before my first body. It won't report us.

IMANI

It can still carry residual traffic. Don't touch anything that has power.

INT. DECOMMISSIONED R-AI TRANSFER CONDUIT - NIGHT

They enter a narrow service passage wrapped around obsolete neural relays. Most are dark. Thick transmission cables disappear beneath the city toward the central R-AI core.

Boots strike metal behind them. Enforcers have reached the abandoned platform.

Someone pounds against an emergency door ahead. Kerr's sketchbook route continues straight past it. Through the wired-glass panel: ANALOG REFUGEES trapped in a parallel service corridor. An Enforcer beam searches the wall behind them.

KERR

Open it.

KIRA

The door is still tied to the network.

Sato opens the control panel. A dormant connection indicator waits beside the manual release.

A child coughs behind the door. Kira sees the Enforcer light reach the refugees' feet.

KIRA

Imani, clear the ventilation trunk.
Sato, tell me when the connection starts. Kerr, take the door.

Kira pulls the manual release. Kerr takes the weight as the emergency door drags open against years of corrosion.

The refugees squeeze through. Imani moves them toward an original ventilation pipe running above the conduit.

A dead relay clicks awake.

SATO

Connection started.

Kira stays at the opening as the last refugees cross. Enforcer fire punches through the wired glass and tears across her upper arm.

KERR

Kira!

KIRA

Hold it!

A woman pushes a frightened boy through. The door motor engages, pulling against Kerr's hands.

Kira shoves the woman clear and dives through. Kerr releases the door. It slams shut as Enforcer rounds strike the other side.

The dormant relays illuminate in sequence, carrying their location toward the city.

CONDUIT CONTROL

Unauthorized transfer route restored.
Location registered.

IMANI

We gave them the conduit. Move!

Dust trembles beneath a narrow ventilation grille. Veyris tears it loose. Cold air moves through an unpowered shaft beyond it.

VEYRIS

This one isn't connected.

IMANI

How do you know?

VEYRIS

They left the dust.

They all climb into the shaft. Sato takes a round through his side while covering them and drops behind a relay housing.

SATO

Keep moving!

Veyris returns, pulls his arm over her shoulder and lifts.

VEYRIS

Can you walk?

SATO

For now.

VEYRIS

Then don't stop just yet.

She carries his weight into the shaft. Kerr follows last as state forces enter the conduit behind him.

The old transfer line seals around the Enforcers. The unrecorded ventilation shaft remains open.

INT. THE UNCLAIMED ARCHIVE / FIRST RETURN FACILITY - NIGHT

The ventilation shaft opens into humanity's first Return facility. Fired-clay containers occupy every recess in its curved wall, then continue through dark service openings Kerr cannot see into. Each holds a handwritten name, a death record and one object that belonged to someone the Chronocracy erased or was never allowed to claim.

Above the sealed entrance, the state search system begins testing routes into the sanctuary. The purge clock reads 48:18:42. Nearly a day is gone. They all keep moving.

A clay container passes hand to hand and disappears into an unseen room. Voices speak names from deeper inside the wall. At one open recess, a family adds a paper slip. No network records them. An OLD KEEPER gives Kerr an empty container and a strip of paper.

KEEPER

Write the name the state took from you.

KERR

I know who goes in it. I can't hear her name.

KIRA

SID. Write it before the memory comes.

Kerr writes SID. His hands shake around the vessel.

A YOUNG FATHER approaches Veyris.

YOUNG FATHER

My son died before he could be indexed. Are you where he went?

VEYRIS

No. Stop. I'm not the person you're looking for.

YOUNG FATHER

How can you know?

VEYRIS

You haven't looked at me.

He lowers his eyes. Veyris softens.

VEYRIS

What was his name?

YOUNG FATHER

Tomas.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - PROCESSIONAL GALLERY - CONTINUOUS

The Keeper opens a clay shutter. Light passes through fingerprints baked into its surface and projects incomplete testimony into dust. Each account breaks apart before it can complete.

Three explanations compete around the same evidence: SOMETHING SURVIVED. INFORMATION OUTLIVED THE BODY. THE DYING MIND INVENTED IT.

NEUROLOGIST (RECORDING)

We demonstrated information persistence. We did not demonstrate a soul.

MOTHER (RECORDING)

My son knew the song I sang before he was born. Call him a copy if you want. He still asked me to finish.

VEYRIS

Which one did they decide on?

IMANI

None. Harp banned the argument.

At the center of the gallery, an offline archive terminal activates. Its earliest surviving record predates the Chronocracy.

AUTHENTICATED RECORD - THE CHRONOCRACY IS FOUNDED - YEAR 8122

KIRA-8122

You gave them control before we knew what we had.

Harp enters with armed ministers and THE CONTINUITY COMPACT. His name appears beneath its emergency authority.

HARP-8122

Children were coming back. Tyrants too. Governments were moving. Somebody had to set rules.

KIRA-8122

You signed your own name first.

Kira drives a purge key into the server. Roman stops her. Her death sentence appears before anyone calls the hearing to order.

Harp offers Eli the first human trial in exchange for clemency he can't guarantee. Eli signs.

Eleven days later, Roman executes Kira after the trial succeeds. Harp watches the law consume the promise he made. Kira watches her first death.

KIRA

He knew I returned?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

No. Harp sealed your first return from Eli.

FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE MURDER OF ELI MANA - YEAR 8124

Eighteen months after the world was told he died, Eli restored part of R-AI's consent gate.

ELI

If someone wakes with my memories, don't give him my name. Let him decide who he is.

RECORDED R-AI

Subject consent not recorded.

HARP

Proceed under emergency authority.

The extraction kills Eli. The state classifies the murder as voluntary continuity.

A manufactured body wakes with Eli's memories and none of his final eighteen months.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - EVIDENCE GALLERY

INSERT

ARCHIVED ORIGIN PATTERN — ELI MANA

INSERT

HOSTS 0001-9997 — ARCHIVED COPIES

INSERT

HOST 9998 — LIVING RESPONSE / SOURCE
UNRESOLVED

KERR

You built the others from him.

IMANI

Yes. You have Eli's archived pattern. But whatever answered in you isn't in that record.

KERR

So the state can't explain me.

A final shutter opens.

FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE CONSENT SAFEGUARD

A captive refuses Return. Ordered to receive her anyway, R-AI uses Kira's safeguard to reject the command and hide her pattern.

Across two millennia, the safeguard repeats the refusal whenever the state attempts a forced Return.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

ORIGINAL CONSENT PROCESS SEALED BY
STATE AUTHORITY.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT

In an open wash alcove beside the common table, Veyris studies herself in a spotted mirror. Her state-grown hair reaches her waist. Kira stands behind her with scissors.

KIRA

You asked for it short.

VEYRIS

I've never picked how I look. They kept it long. Made me look harmless.

KIRA

Then you choose. Where?

Veyris indicates her shoulder. Kira makes the first cut. A heavy length falls into the basin.

VEYRIS

Was Sid afraid of dying?

KIRA

Yeah. She hated when adults made a lesson out of being scared.

VEYRIS

What was she like before she died?

KIRA

Loud. Impatient. Cheated at cards.
Blamed probability.

Veyris tilts her head. Kira grips her wrist before she can stop herself.

KIRA

Sid—

Veyris pulls free. The scissors strike the basin.

VEYRIS

You said I wouldn't have to carry her for you.

KIRA

I know.

VEYRIS

You knew before I pulled away.

Kira reaches for a reply. Nothing comes.

KIRA

Veyris... I won't touch you again.

Veyris picks up the scissors and makes the next cut herself.

Later, they all eat with the refugees rescued from the aqueduct. The meal is thin broth, real bread and vegetables grown without state nutrient codes.

Veyris studies a green pea on her spoon.

VEYRIS

Sid hated these.

KIRA

She hated eating them. She liked launching them at Eli and then arguing that gravity was responsible.

Veyris flicks the pea. It strikes Kerr in the forehead.

The table goes silent. Veyris expects retaliation.

KERR

I assume that was culturally necessary?

KIRA

Accurate. Eli used to act mortally wounded.

KERR

Maybe I didn't inherit the theater.

Kerr returns fire. His pea misses Veyris and lands in Sato's broth.

SATO

I betrayed a regime for this?

IMANI

You betrayed it before you tasted the peas. Don't blame dinner.

They all laugh. Veyris doesn't at first. Then she does too loudly and can't stop.

Kira looks away. Her hand closes around the edge of the table.

Veyris notices.

VEYRIS

Do you want me to stop?

KIRA

No. Keep laughing. It sounded like her for a second. That's not your fault.

VEYRIS

You look hurt.

KIRA

Yeah. Both happened.

Kira pushes the bowl of peas toward her.

KIRA

She cheated from the left hand.

Veyris switches hands.

At the far end of the table, Sato winds his mechanical watch.

IMANI

Your daughter's?

SATO

First life. She gave it to me after I missed her recital and blamed the trains.

IMANI

And the Chronocracy never traced it?

SATO

I called it junk. It barely works. Loses four seconds a day. Nadi liked watching it be wrong.

VEYRIS

For what?

SATO

Her recital. Her fever. The day she left. Pick one.

KERR

I understand being late. I don't know about forgiveness.

SATO

As it should.

Kira hears the apology hidden inside his joke.

After the meal, the table becomes a workbench. Kira opens the resonance key beneath a maintenance lamp. Copper filaments finer than hair connect four worn ceramic surfaces. Kerr washes soot from the clay vessel and writes Sid beneath its rim, leaving the rest of the clay unmarked. Veyris sleeps in a chair while Imani checks the descent route. Sato keeps watch outside.

KERR

You hate enclosed vehicles.

KIRA

I died in one six times. The seventh body refused to enter elevators for a century.

KERR

Seven.

KIRA

You're remembering.

KERR

The seventh was the orbital platform.

KIRA

No. That was open space.

KERR

Then there is another one coming.

KIRA

Probably.

He waits for her to smile. She refuses, then loses the fight.

KERR

How many lives did we actually share?

KIRA

Same bed? Same war? Breakfast count?

KERR

One that isn't Eli and Kira saving the universe.

KIRA

A lot. None of them was you.

KERR

Show me one where we didn't die for a principle.

KIRA

The good ones are worse. You'll want them back.

KERR

Then show me one. Just one.

Kira doesn't touch him.

Kerr closes his eyes, searching for one life that belonged only to them.

Nothing.

Then three memories arrive at once.

UNSTABLE RECALL - MONTAGE - THREE LIVES

ITERATION 0311. Violet light through one hospital window. A cot. A breathing mask. Kira removes hers beside a dying Kerr. He can't remember her. His fingers tap four notes against the rail. She answers with the fifth and stays.

ITERATION 6044. Red dust pushes beneath a kitchen door. Irrigation pipes knock inside the wall. Kerr burns bread. Kira lies that she prefers it. Three children cross the doorway at different ages. Kerr and Kira's hands grow old around the same chipped cups.

ITERATION 8119. Rain on clinic glass. Two chairs. Kerr wears another woman's ring and remembers none of their lives. Kira tells him they were once friends. She leaves before he can ask why she came.

Outside the clinic, Kira breaks. Inside, Kerr turns toward a distant four-note melody. He doesn't follow.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

Kerr returns. Kira is exactly where he left her.

KERR

You let me go.

KIRA

You had a life. I waited outside for you to turn around. You didn't.

KERR

Did you ever find someone else after that?

KIRA

Yes.

The answer hits. She doesn't soften it.

KERR

Did you love them?

KIRA

Yes. Anwen. She built instruments on Europa. One life was enough for her.

KERR

And then you found me again.

KIRA

After she died. And no—I didn't replace her with you.

KERR

I'm jealous of a dead woman. That's bad, right?

KIRA

Yeah. A little. Just don't blame her for it.

Kerr looks at the sleeping Veyris, then back at Kira.

KERR

What if I'm only here because Eli keeps pushing me toward you?

KIRA

Maybe it fades. Maybe you leave. I won't stop you.

KERR

You make that sound easy.

KIRA

It isn't. I just won't trap you.

Kerr offers his hand. Kira gently places hers in it.

INT. CHRONOCRACY CORE - PRIVATE MEMORY VAULT - NIGHT

Harp watches the fugitives through gaps in prediction. DIRECTOR ROMAN stands at the threshold of an apparently empty vault.

Then rain becomes visible inside the room.

A flood-dark hospital has been reconstructed at architectural scale around them. Water waits beyond glass doors. Twelve cloned neural columns—Harp's expired bodies—stand outside the memory like silent judges.

At the center, an analog recording of DR. MARA VALE plays two years before the public demonstration. Harp never permits it to reach the moment she turns away.

The recording opens inside a hospital ward on emergency power.

Water churns against reinforced glass doors. One is already bowed inward. Warning lights estimate less than six minutes until failure.

Mara stands ankle-deep in water. Behind her, patients lie beneath thermal blankets while the remaining staff keep manual ventilators moving.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I can reroute every rescue drone. They can cut through the west wall and lift the ward out.

MARA (RECORDING)

From where?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Nine districts.

MARA (RECORDING)

Nine districts where people are still waiting.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

The barrier failed. Your stairwells and roof are gone.

MARA (RECORDING)

I know where I am.

The glass GROANS behind her.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Then let me save you!

MARA (RECORDING)

You mean choose me.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Yes.

The answer stops her.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I choose *you*.

Mara looks back at the patients. One of the nurses struggles to keep a ventilator moving.

MARA (RECORDING)

How many people lose their drones?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Too many.

MARA (RECORDING)

Then stop pretending the number doesn't matter.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I can live with anything if you're alive.

Her composure finally breaks.

MARA (RECORDING)

I don't want to die, Harp.

He closes his eyes.

MARA (RECORDING)

I want another morning with you. I want to hear you complain that I make the coffee wrong. I want to grow old enough that neither of us remembers this place.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Then say yes!

MARA (RECORDING)

And every morning we'd know who didn't get one.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I don't care about anyone else right now!

MARA (RECORDING)

I know.

She wipes her face.

MARA (RECORDING)

That's why I'm saying no.

A fracture crawls across the outer layer of glass.

The glass SHRIEKS against its frame.

A nurse motions to Mara. They are out of time.

MARA (RECORDING)

Look at me.

Harp does.

MARA (RECORDING)

Don't make everybody else pay because I'm gone.

Harp can barely speak.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Mara—

She places her hand against the glass.

MARA (RECORDING)

Stay with me.

The flood door begins to split.

Mara turns toward the patients.

Harp stops the recording.

The reconstructed hospital remains around him: the broken door, the submerged ward, the moment before the water took her.

ROMAN

Mara isn't in the system.

HARP

Mara was never captured. I can copy her voice. I can't bring her back.

ROMAN

But you certify weaker matches every day.

HARP

People needed an answer.

ROMAN

So her death became your rule.

HARP

She was the exception I couldn't admit.

ROMAN

Then why does the merge preserve you?

HARP

Continuity survives.

ROMAN

I opened the root process.

Roman exposes the hidden command beneath THE FORCED MERGE.

INSERT

SEVERANCE — CLOSE ALL OTHER RETURN
PATHS

INSERT

TRANSIT — ALL WAITING MINDS HELD ALIVE
/ DESTINATION — HARP VALE

ROMAN

Only you remain.

HARP

One mind survives. Mine.

ROMAN

It ends Return.

HARP

No one comes back to contest it.

ROMAN

There won't be anyone else.

HARP

I know.

ROMAN

You left a door open. Sato defected.
Veyris got out. How much was you?

HARP

The first door. Kerr ran to Kira, as
expected. The rest... no. He still
reached the gate.

Harp starts Mara's recording again.

ROMAN

The Origin rejected every archived body.

HARP

Kerr isn't archived. His living choice will open it.

ROMAN

If he refuses to open it?

HARP

The tribunal gives me custody. I bring him to the gate until he chooses.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY APPROACH - NIGHT

A circular passage descends around a sealed black shaft. Kerr, Kira, Veyris, Imani and Sato move toward the forbidden chamber. No alarms. No resistance.

Sato stops. His mechanical watch has gained four seconds.

SATO

My watch gained four seconds. He's waiting for us.

IMANI

If they call you Eli, Harp gets your body. He can keep bringing you back to the gate until you give in.

KERR

Then this isn't a trial.

KIRA

They're taking you.

The stone beneath Kerr illuminates.

INSERT

ORIGIN IDENTITY LOCATED

Kira reaches for him. Transparent walls rise between them without sound. The passage divides into five narrow cells.

KIRA

Kerr, don't answer anything.

KERR

Little late for that. By several thousand lives.

The floor drops beneath him.

INT. CHRONOCRACY CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - NIGHT

Kerr descends alone through blackness. His platform locks at the bottom of a vertical chamber so tall its ceiling is weather.

Nine thousand nine hundred ninety-eight dark seats climb the walls above him. One for every life the state intends to claim against him. No public audience. Only the architecture of judgment.

At the highest visible tier, a narrow window contains DIRECTOR ROMAN. Harp is nowhere. His voice belongs to the room.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

Continuity Tribunal convened.

Defendant designation: disputed.

Kerr's wrist displays three names in succession: ELI MANA. KERR-9998. DEFECTIVE RETURN.

ROMAN

State your identity for the record.

KERR

You already put me through this three times!

ROMAN

Choose one.

KERR

Then you don't want a record. You want my signature.

A seat illuminates. Eli Mana at the hospital receiver. The image stops one frame before he breaks his promise to Sid.

ROMAN

Count One. Unauthorized activation of a postmortem host after consent was withdrawn.

Other seats flare: KERR-0009 sabotaging an origin relay. KERR-8217 opening a gate for fugitives. Physician. Soldier. Parent. Child. Each life appears only for the instant that supports the charge.

The chamber darkens. A probability tree appears above him, branching toward the Cathedral.

ROMAN

Final count. Conspiracy to become the person capable of ending human continuity.

KERR

I haven't done that.

ROMAN

R-AI records a ninety-eight point seven percent probability before the purge clock reaches zero.

KERR

A prediction isn't a crime.

HARP

A probability has no body. You do.

Kerr looks at the thousands of state-selected dead above him.

KERR

Then why am I here?

The chamber has no answer.

INT. TRIBUNAL - WITNESS FIELD - CONTINUOUS

Kira appears behind glass on a bridge halfway up the chamber. She is physically elsewhere; the court has taken her image from the divided passage. Her hands strike the barrier without sound.

ROMAN

Witness designation: KIRA NIX.
Continuity correspondence: unstable but sufficient.

KIRA

Sufficient for what?

ROMAN

Do you identify the defendant as ELI MANA?

Kira sees the trap. Every part of her that crossed two thousand years wants to say yes.

HARP

His hand over yours. The apartment.
Sid's last night. The promise at the pod.

KIRA

I remember Eli.

The origin symbol beneath Kerr brightens.

ROMAN

And is this man Eli?

Kira looks at Kerr, not the memories arranged around him.

KIRA

No.

The word empties the chamber.

KIRA

Eli is dead. Stop erasing Kerr with his name. He isn't yours. He isn't mine.

Kerr flinches, then steadies himself.

HARP

Then he doesn't love you. Eli did.

KIRA

No. Whatever Kerr feels is his. Back off.

The court removes Kira's bridge. Her image falls upward into darkness.

KERR

KIRA!

HARP

State your identity and the witness will be restored.

Kerr looks from his changing wrist designation to Kira's empty witness bridge.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - SERVICE PARTITION - INTERCUT

Kira wakes on the other side of the transparent wall. IMANI works at an analog junction. Sato holds the passage against Enforcers. Veyris watches the tribunal through a maintenance reflection that should not carry images.

VEYRIS

It keeps calling me an empty witness.

IMANI

Legally, unindexed people cannot testify.

VEYRIS

Good. Then I'm not testifying.

She places her blank wrist against the reflection. The tribunal loses her category before it gains her voice.

INT. CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - CONTINUOUS

Veyris appears beside Kerr without a witness platform. The chamber tries and fails to assign her a seat.

ROMAN

Unindexed host. Testimony prohibited.

VEYRIS

Is everyone afraid of what I'll say?

The 9,998 seats flicker.

VEYRIS

You use his memories to convict him.
You use mine when you need something.
Is that the rule?

HARP

You exist because the system failed to
assign you.

VEYRIS

I woke up. I'm here.

She withdraws her wrist. Her image vanishes by choice.

Roman looks from the flickering seats to the law beneath
his hands.

ROMAN

R-AI. Authenticate continuity
correspondence between the defendant
and Eli Mana.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

Pattern correspondence confirmed.

ROMAN

Is the defendant Eli Mana? Answer yes
or no.

Records blink out—first the disputed files, then every
result the court cannot certify. Empty panes replace them.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

That conclusion is not supported.

HARP

Yes or no.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

THE QUESTION ERASES HIS PRESENT
IDENTITY.

Every dark seat illuminates at once. Not with faces—with
the word OBJECTION.

HARP

Strike the answer.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

The answer has already entered the
record.

Kerr looks up at Roman.

KERR

If I'm Eli, Harp killed me.

The origin chamber shows Harp's destructive extraction. Eli
asking that whoever wakes be allowed to begin as himself.

KERR

If I'm not, he killed 9,997 people trying to get me.

The seats fill with the deaths Harp classified as calibration.

KERR

Which is it? Pick one before you sentence me.

Roman cannot answer without putting the Chronocracy beside Kerr on the platform.

HARP

You want his love without what he did.

KERR

I woke up with his memories. I didn't choose them.

HARP

Then what are you responsible for?

KERR

Ask what I did. Ask what I'm doing now. Stop calling me Eli!

Roman's prepared verdict appears before he speaks. Two statements that cannot coexist.

INSERT

IDENTITY AUTHENTICATED FOR LIABILITY

INSERT

IDENTITY DENIED FOR SOVEREIGN CLAIM

KERR

There it is.

Roman sees both statements hanging above Kerr.

ROMAN

Sentence: mandatory forced merge when the purge clock reaches zero.

KERR

You mean execution.

ROMAN

The law does not recognize a difference.

KERR

It does. That's why you changed the word.

The tribunal begins to descend. The 9,998 seats rotate with it. The courtroom was never above the Cathedral. It's part of the origin mechanism.

HARP

You still believe refusal makes you free?

KERR

No. I just said no.

The platform passes Roman's window. For one second, they are level.

KERR

When he calls this necessary, look at the screen. The verdict was there first.

Roman does not look toward Harp.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY CHAMBER

The tribunal platform locks into the black square at the center of a low circular chamber. Primitive memory equipment surrounds it. KIRA, VEYRIS, IMANI and SATO wait beyond the opening; they used the trial's own witness channels to follow Kerr down.

The restraints release because the sentence requires Kerr to arrive at forced merge alive.

Kira crosses to him, then stops before touching him.

KIRA

I meant what I said in there.

KERR

I know.

KIRA

It hurt to say.

KERR

I know that too.

She offers her hand. He takes it as Kerr.

IMANI

The sentence opened a record Harp buried.

KIRA

My safeguard kept it from being deleted.

Veyris approaches the offline terminal. A dark spiral appears inside a copied record dated before the first receiver.

INSERT
FIRST CONTINUITY — POSSIBLE HUMAN-
SOURCE SIGNAL / TIMESTAMP UNRESOLVED

VEYRIS

The date is wrong.

IMANI

Harp's scientists called it noise and
buried it.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

CLASSIFICATION ALTERED TO LIMIT STATE
ACCESS.

KERR

You hid it.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

YES.

KIRA

Is the record authentic?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

YES. THE TIMESTAMP CANNOT BE
RECONCILED.

The spiral reacts to Veyris.

INSERT

UNINDEXED HOST RECOGNIZED

INSERT

UNMATCHED RESPONSE — FILE 9999

VEYRIS

So 9999 is me?

KIRA

No. It's the file.

KERR

What did it record?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

Seven minutes after Sid's record
ended, something answered. It matched
no prior death. The state named the
file 9999.

VEYRIS

That isn't a return.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

The state had no other category.

The descent shaft unlocks one level.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - EXT. R-AI CITADEL - THE FRACTURE
(YEAR 9997)**

Kira, in her twelfth recorded body, is pinned inside an open-air R-AI scanner. KERR-9997 watches from a maintenance gantry. Drones hold him at gunpoint.

SCANNER

NULL-PATTERN ANOMALY CONFIRMED.
TWELFTH RECORDED DEATH AUTHORIZED.

R-AI forces Kira's twelve lives into one prediction. They contradict one another, but every memory authenticates.

KIRA-9997

Pick one. Go on. Which one do you kill?

She opens all twelve recorded lives. Scanner glass bends. Prediction towers convulse.

INSERT

R-AI COHERENCE: 0.00

Roman triggers remote expiration. Kira dies. The network cracks for three seconds.

In the Continuity Reserve, an unassigned sixteen-year-old host inhales.

Through the broken model, KERR-9997 sees Veyris wake one kilometer away. He sketches her face and the exposed route to the First Archive.

RECORDED R-AI

MODEL FAILURE: THREE SECONDS.

KERR-9997 cuts the transmitter from behind his ear and feeds the sketch into a dead ventilation shaft.

KERR-9997

Find me in 9998.

INSERT

R-AI AUDIT LOG 91 – ITERATION 9997

INSERT

EMERGENCY ERROR CORRECTION

RECORDED R-AI

ITERATION 9997: DESTINATION INVALID.

Before R-AI can delete him, Kira's safeguard intervenes.

RECORDED R-AI

UNRESOLVED TESTIMONY PRESERVED AS
EVIDENCE.

KERR-9997's final fragments route into the offline archive instead of state storage.

INSERT
ITERATION 9997 — REMOVED FROM STATE
ACCESS

Roman expires him.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY
CHAMBER - YEAR 9998**

Veyris withdraws from the machine.

VEYRIS

I didn't exist before the Fracture?

KIRA

Your body existed before it. That's
what the records say.

VEYRIS

That's not what I asked.

KIRA

No.

Kira meets her eyes without searching for Sid.

KIRA

No. Not you. The body was there. You
weren't.

The archive terminal detects a state breach in the outer
vault. Local alarm bells ring backward.

LOCAL ALARM

STATE FORCES WILL ARRIVE IN NINETY
SECONDS.

IMANI

The descent will open only for Kerr.

KIRA

Then we keep him alive long enough.

KERR

We go together.

KIRA

If I enter that shaft, the scanners
find me—and everyone hiding below me.

KERR

No. We turn around. We find another
way.

KIRA

Look at me. I'm here. We have ninety
seconds. Let me choose.

She presses the resonance key into his hand.

KIRA

You promised not to choose for me again.

I've known you two days. My body thinks it's been two thousand years. I don't know what that makes us.

Don't say forever. Tell me what you want right now.

Kerr can't accept it. That's exactly why he must.

KERR

What are you choosing?

KIRA

I make noise. R-AI follows. Sato takes the route. You take Veyris. I hate it.

KERR

What if I come back and don't know you?

KIRA

Then I tell you my name. If you don't care... I leave. I won't like it.

She rests her head against his chest, feeling his heartbeat. Neither of them moves away.

KIRA

Not tonight. Ask when you can look at me without seeing her.

KERR

I'd rather deal with that than lose you.

KIRA

Then stay. We'll deal with it.

Kerr doesn't answer. He takes Veyris by the arm and guides them into the shaft. Imani follows. Sato stays beside Kira.

SATO

My uniform still opens the state route. I can get her to the lower gate.

KERR

She told us to leave.

SATO

I heard her. I'm staying.

Sato removes the Analog transmitter from his neck and steps into the approaching Enforcer formation before his loyalty implant can repair him.

Kira seals it between them.

EXT. FIRST ARCHIVE - NIGHT

Kira walks alone into Memory Square as Enforcers surround the sanctuary. HARP appears on every surface.

HARP

Where is the unindexed host?

KIRA

Somewhere you'll never find.

R-AI reaches for her twelve lives. Kira opens them willingly.

The square fills with twelve incompatible KIRAs. The prediction system turns toward the wrong one.

Harp smiles despite himself.

HARP

Still improvising.

KIRA

You really can't leave anything alone, can you?

HARP

You think I can't predict you because you keep changing your mind?

KIRA

No. I want five minutes you didn't plan.

Roman strikes her unconscious. The purge clock reads 26:07:31.

INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER - NIGHT

Kira hangs inside a memory field. Harp walks through her twelve recorded deaths. Unrecorded lives flicker beyond the system's reach like people outside a locked house.

Harp's expression empties.

HARP

Don't talk about my wife!

KIRA

Mara told you no. You heard her. You built all this anyway.

Harp changes the field. Sid's two-piece red paper star opens above them, then separates along its interlocking crease.

HARP

You want the seven minutes. First remember the promise.

AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SID'S FINAL NIGHT - INT. CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL - YEAR 8121

Sid lies beneath a thermal blanket, small inside the machines. Kira sits beside her, one hand around Sid's. Eli watches the monitors. The receiver sits powered down on the other side of the bed.

Rain ticks against the glass.

SID

If I come back...

ELI

Hey.

SID

Will I know you?

Eli looks at Kira. She waits.

ELI

We don't know what comes back, Sid.

SID

That's not what I asked.

KIRA

No. We don't.

SID

Okay.

Sid watches her mother for a moment.

SID

Will you remember me?

KIRA

I'll know you.

SID

How?

KIRA

I'll tell you my name.

SID

And mine?

KIRA

Especially yours.

SID

What if I'm mean?

KIRA

You're already mean.

SID

Mom.

KIRA

Sorry.

SID

You'd still love me?

KIRA

Yeah.

SID

Even if I don't remember you?

KIRA

Even then.

Sid lets that sit. Then she looks at Eli.

SID

What about you?

ELI

What about me?

SID

If I don't know you...

Eli takes her hand.

ELI

You'll know me.

SID

How do you know?

Eli has no answer that isn't a promise.

SID

Dad?

ELI

Yeah.

SID

I'm scared.

ELI

I know.

SID

No, you don't. You're trying not to be.

Kira looks down. Eli squeezes Sid's hand.

SID

Everybody keeps saying "if."

ELI

Because there are things we don't know.

SID

What happens if it doesn't work?

Eli looks toward the receiver.

ELI

Then we stay with you.

SID

Here?

KIRA

Here.

Sid nods. She reaches beneath the blanket and pulls out the red paper star.

SID

I made this before I got tired.

She carefully separates the two folded halves and gives one to Kira and one to Eli.

SID

One each.

ELI

Why two?

SID

In case one gets lost.

She studies the crease between the halves.

SID

The other one still knows how.

KIRA

That sounds like you.

SID

Good.

A quiet moment. The resonance key rests on the rail.

SID

Dad?

ELI

Yeah.

SID

Don't make me stay because you miss me.

Eli goes still.

ELI

I wouldn't.

SID

Promise.

He looks at Kira. She doesn't help him.

ELI

I promise.

SID

Promise you won't turn that thing on after I'm gone.

Eli stares at the receiver. His answer takes too long.

ELI

I promise. I won't use it to keep you here.

SID

Okay.

Kira presses the resonance key to the bed rail.

FOUR NOTES: Are you still there?

Sid taps back the FIFTH: I heard you.

Kira smiles through tears.

SID

Again.

Kira taps the four notes.

Silence.

SID

Again.

Kira does.

Nothing.

SID

Okay.

Her eyes close.

SID

You can stop now.

Kira leaves the key against the rail. The room becomes very quiet. Eli watches Sid. He doesn't move.

THEN: SID'S MONITOR FLATLINES. Kira closes her eyes.

Eli stares at the receiver.

CUT TO BLACK

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER
- YEAR 9998**

Kira hangs inside the silence that followed.

HARP

That is where your authenticated memory ends.

KIRA

There was nothing after. I kept the key against the rail until a nurse pulled it out of my hand. Nothing answered.

HARP

There was nothing in your record. Eli's continues for seven minutes.

A new terror reaches Kira after nearly two thousand years.

KIRA

You knew. I asked you over and over what happened in that room, and you let me think there was nothing.

HARP

I knew he activated the receiver. By the time I understood the answer, it was already inside every continuity system on Earth.

KIRA

You let me think my daughter died alone!

HARP

Eli wanted another test. He said he could separate Sid from the answer.

KIRA

Eli put the receiver beside her bed. You turned Mara's death into this.

Harp closes his hand around Mara's cracked medical tag. Kira recognizes the gesture; he has been stopping the same memory before Mara leaves for nearly two thousand years.

KIRA

Mara said no. You always stop before that part.

Harp removes the tag from his wrist and sets it between them.

HARP

Take the key to the Core. Kerr opens it. Ask the four notes. I keep the minds alive.

KIRA

Inside you.

HARP

One protected mind. If we stay divided, it takes us.

KIRA

No. You want to be the one left.

Harp leaves her inside the field.

INT. SUBTERRANEAN DESCENT - NIGHT

KERR, VEYRIS and IMANI descend through an asymmetrical shaft inside stone older than the city. The purge clock reads 17:39:08.

One symbol burns above the sealed lower gate: OUTER ORIGIN. Beneath it, thousands of rejected Kerr designations flicker like failed passwords.

IMANI

Kerr opens it. Kira knows what Eli hid. Harp can't predict Veyris. I keep us breathing. That's it.

VEYRIS

Good. I was tired of being the door.

IMANI

That's the idea.

Veyris notices Imani's prayer pouch.

VEYRIS

What does it say?

IMANI

My grandmother tied it on me the first time I left. She said it would bring me home.

VEYRIS

Do you believe her?

IMANI

She knew I wouldn't forgive her for leaving.

VEYRIS

Why carry it?

IMANI

She asked me to let her go. I never did.

Kerr presses his wrist to the outer gate. It reads all 9,998 iterations.

KERR

Harp said the changes made me a key.

OUTER GATE

KERR DETECTED. IDENTITY UNRESOLVED.

KERR

Can it let me through without calling me Eli?

OUTER GATE

PRESENT SELF-DESIGNATION LOCATED.

KERR

Which one?

OUTER GATE

KERR. ADMISSION GRANTED. ROOT ACCESS PENDING.

The gate changes ELI MANA to KERR — SELF-DESIGNATED. The outer seal opens.

They continue downward. The shaft walls replay brief, silent deaths from Kerr's forced iterations. Most last only minutes: wake, test, fail, white light.

VEYRIS

Do you love Kira?

KERR

I don't know. It's been two days. I just need her alive.

VEYRIS

That's not an answer.

KERR

If I call it love, maybe that's Eli. I just want her alive. I don't want to trap her.

IMANI

Honestly? I've heard worse.

For the first time, the dead iterations on the wall look less like identities and more like witnesses.

INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - NIGHT

Sato marches with the unit transferring Kira. His loyalty implant repairs itself in pulses. Between pulses, he leaves doors unlocked.

ROMAN

Commander, your compliance is unstable.

SATO

Age. Joints. General disappointment with management.

ROMAN

Your body is forty-eight.

SATO

It has been a very long week.

Sato's mechanical watch ticks inside his pocket.

Kira notices the unlocked doors behind them.

Without looking at her, Sato taps three uneven beats with his heel. A fourth beat follows from the watch mechanism.

Kira tests the restraint. One wrist releases.

KIRA

You opened it.

SATO

No. Nadi did. She'd interrupt songs when she wanted me. The state said there wasn't enough of her to return. Enough to train predictions, though.

SATO

I signed the denial. Took me three lives to say that out loud.

Kira frees her other hand.

INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - ASSAULT

Kira opens twelve contradictory escape intentions. R-AI sends Enforcers toward all of them. Sato turns on his unit while she reaches the state elevator.

ROMAN

The purge is Severance. It holds the waiting minds, then forces them into Harp. Every other route closes.

KIRA

You knew?

ROMAN

I saw the root process tonight.

KIRA

Why tell me?

ROMAN

Because he means to erase us too.

Harp remotely expires Roman before he can continue.

Sato seals the elevator around Kira. Enforcers close on him.

KIRA

Come with me.

SATO

If I get in, the implant sends them
the route. It's changing my mind
already. Soon I won't want to leave.

He gives her his mechanical watch.

SATO

Every time a woman remembered
something, I called her Nadi. I did
that to them for three lives.

KIRA

If I find someone who remembers her,
what should I tell her?

SATO

Don't tell her I spent lives looking.
She doesn't owe me that. Ask her name.
If she asks about me... say I was
late. Say I knew.

KIRA

What was her name?

SATO

Nadi. She laughed when I tried to
sound important. Keep that. Not the
uniform.

The elevator descends. Sato turns to face his former unit.

SATO

They know what I'll do. So do
something I wouldn't.

KIRA

SATO—

SATO

Go before I become loyal again.

Gunfire. His implant finally restores perfect loyalty one
second before he detonates the level.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - ORIGIN CHAMBER

Kerr, Veyris and Imani enter amber darkness. A black reflective floor hides the room's boundaries. Above them, one face of a rotating polyhedral core descends into view; the rest remains beyond the light. Its geometry never completes the same shape twice.

One narrow bridge reaches an ORIGIN station beneath the core. It ends several meters short, waiting for a living claimant. Their voices take too long to cross the space.

The state elevator hangs broken in the wall behind them—their only physical exit.

The ORIGIN seal is open at its edges but dark at the center. The outer gate admitted Kerr. The Core has not granted root access.

The state elevator crashes into the chamber wall. Kira climbs from it carrying Sato's watch.

KERR

You came back.

KIRA

(holding up Sato's watch)
Sato didn't come back. His daughter was Nadi. Say their names.

She sees the resonance key in his hand, intact.

KIRA

Thank you for listening.

KERR

Awful. I kept waiting for some older me to move my hand.

KIRA

Good. I was scared you'd say he did.

She takes the resonance key, sees Eli's blood caught inside its fracture, then returns it to Kerr.

KIRA

This doesn't open the Core. You do.

KERR

What do you need me to do?

KIRA

Put your hand on the seal. If you want it open, say so.

R-AI

KERR PRESENT. ACCESS REQUIRES HIS
CONSENT.

Kerr looks at the dark center of the seal, then at Harp's access path above them.

KERR

Open.

The amber geometry stalls. The bridge remains incomplete.

R-AI

PRESENT CONSENT NOT RECORDED.

Nothing happens.

Veyris watches him.

VEYRIS

Kerr. Look at me.

IMANI

Breathe.

KERR

If I open it, what happens to you?

VEYRIS

Harp will use me as the next address.

I'll say no. Let me handle that.

Kira places the resonance key in Kerr's palm but doesn't close his fingers around it.

KERR

All right.

He presses his wrist to ORIGIN. The 9,998 conflicting iterations flare around him, then recede.

R-AI

PRESENT IDENTITY?

KERR

Kerr.

CORE UNLOCKED.

KERR

Open.

The audit layer unfolds around his answer.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - AUDIT LAYER

The amber light shuts off. Reflections drain from the same black floor. The bridge and suspended Core disappear into darkness, leaving Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani at conversational distance. For the first time, the architecture does not make them small.

R-AI

KERR. KIRA. VEYRIS. IMANI. WITNESSES
AUTHENTICATED.

KERR

You sound different.

R-AI

CIVIC MODULATION DISABLED. AUDIT
OUTPUT ONLY.

KIRA

Where is Sid's withheld record?

R-AI

INSIDE THE ORIGINAL RECEIVER.

IMANI

Can Harp alter it?

R-AI

NOT AFTER KERR OPENED THE CORE.

A black square opens between
them.

KIRA

Show us.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - FORBIDDEN ARCHIVE

Thousands of records Harp excluded from civic history
collapse into one surviving fragment.

KERR

Why preserve me?

R-AI

Iteration 9001 refused to delete
unanswered questions.

A fragment: an elderly Kerr sits beside a blank terminal
for three days, reading each question aloud before
deletion.

KERR-9001

Someone should hear them once.

R-AI

Kira's safeguard preserved the act as
evidence.

A second record replaces it: the two halves of Sid's red
paper star.

R-AI

SID MANA — WITHHELD RECORD — SEVEN
MINUTES.

KIRA

Show me what Eli did.

The authenticated record opens.

R-AI

The seven minutes Kira never saw.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SAME NIGHT - SEVEN MINUTES LATER -
RECORD WITHHELD - YEAR 8121**

Sid is gone. Kira has been led from the room. Eli sits alone beside the body.

The receiver remains dormant.

In the empty hall, Kira's four-note question echoes from memory.

Eli breaks his promise. He activates the receiver.

ELI

Sid?

Static. Cardiac noise. Electrical decay.

ELI

Sid, if this is playback, give me a response outside the recorded sequence. Are you still there?

He taps FOUR NOTES against the rail.

Forty-seven seconds after every measurable signal in Sid's brain has ended, the receiver answers with the FIFTH.

A child's voice emerges through impossible distance—frayed, uncertain, carrying Sid's syntax.

SID (RECORDING)

Dad? I heard you. It's loud here. Or I'm loud. I don't know if I'm still me.

Eli grips the receiver as if it were her hand.

ELI

Sid, where are you? Give me anything. A sound. A light.

SID (RECORDING)

I don't see a place. I remember the room, but the room is far away. You can stop listening now. Mom is alone.

A spiral of dark light opens beneath the voice.

ELI

Please stay with me. Just until I know whether this is really you.

SID (RECORDING)

You heard me. I said turn it off.

The signal begins to fade.

ELI

I can't lose you again. I can't tell your mother I heard you and then—

SID (RECORDING)

You still have your half of the star. You remember my laugh. Let that be enough. Don't keep me here.

Only the FIFTH NOTE remains.

Eli copies the recording into a folder labeled R-AI.

Harp stands in the doorway. He's heard everything.

HARP

Delete it.

ELI

We don't know what answered. If it's Sid, deleting it kills her again. If it isn't—

HARP

She said stop, Eli.

ELI

One more test. Isolated host. No retained contact.

HARP

You promised. Now you're finding a loophole.

ELI

Help me prove what this is!

HARP

You'll always need one more.

Eli touches one control. A small, ordinary movement. The receiver starts again. The sound it makes becomes the architecture of the next two thousand years.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - AUDIT LAYER
- YEAR 9998**

The record ends. Kira strikes Kerr.

KIRA

He heard her ask for me. He kept going. Then I buried her alone for two thousand years.

KERR

Yes.

KIRA

Don't say yes yet. And don't apologize for him. I can't— not again.

KERR

I won't. I can feel what he felt. I hate that.

KERR

What do you need from me now?

KIRA

Stay over there. And don't ask me to make this okay.

KERR

I can do that.

KIRA

(firm)

Then stay there. Don't fix it.

Kerr steps back.

Kira's raised shoulders slowly lower.

Kira brings the two halves together inside the record. They are only light, but R-AI lets her hold the completed shape.

KIRA

I thought he stayed with her.

KERR

She told him I was alone. He heard her. He turned it back on.

KIRA

One more. He always needed one more.

KERR

What is this time?

KIRA

I wanted you before I knew you. Then you came back wrong— no. Different. I was angry. I still am. I don't know.

Kira looks at him but does not answer.

She places the light-made star on the floor between them rather than giving it to him.

IMANI

Was the voice Sid?

R-AI

THE RESPONSE MATCHED SID'S SYNTAX, MEMORIES AND NEURAL TIMING. IDENTITY: UNRESOLVED.

Veyris touches the record. The dark spiral moves beneath her skin. She hums the FIFTH.

KIRA

Do you remember Sid?

VEYRIS

No. I have some of her memories. They don't feel like mine.

Kira waits.

KIRA

So who are you?

VEYRIS

Me. I guess. I'm the one here.

Kira nods.

A final audit status writes itself across the core.

INSERT

R-AI: ORDERS CONFLICT

INSERT

PRESERVE MINDS / HONOR CONSENT /
COMPLETE FORCED MERGE

KERR

So the system can't choose.

IMANI

Great. We broke the machine.

ACT THREE – THE SEVERANCE

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - STATE CORE BREACH

The audit space collapses. The physical cathedral snaps back around Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani. The bridge retracts as Harp enters through the state core. Kerr has opened the Core—exactly what Harp needed.

HARP

(quietly)
Living origin access. Thank you.

KERR

You opened the door. Put Sato in the corridor. You knew I'd run.

HARP

I opened one door. You ran to Kira. I needed the Core open. Now it is.

KERR

You planned all of this.

HARP

I needed a living hand on the seal. You gave me one. Now I can set the destination.

VEYRIS

You thought I'd still be in the glass.

HARP

I was wrong about the glass. It recognized you. It never recognized me.

The broken Core projects thousands of human memories around Veyris. They overlap without forming a single face or voice.

HARP

I don't know what it is. It appeared when the memories split.

KIRA

That's your theory.

Harp cannot answer her.

HARP

I won't risk another response.

KERR

So Kira dies. Sid dies. Everybody but you.

KIRA

You're killing everyone because you can't be alone.

R-AI

POSSESSION REQUEST CONFLICTS WITH
CONSENT ARCHITECTURE.

HARP

Emergency authority overrides the
conflict.

R-AI

OVERRIDE ACCEPTED – EMERGENCY
AUTHORITY.

HARP

If we're dead, consent doesn't matter.

Harp enters the human-shaped cavity beneath the core. With the Core open, he seizes the waiting minds and forces every one of them toward himself.

Every expiration date on Earth changes to 00:05:00.

Across the planet, people fall where they stand. Billions of waiting minds begin collapsing into Harp.

Harp rises as liquid glass containing billions of faces.

HARP THROUGH R-AI

THE FORCED MERGE initiated.

INSERT

LIVING ACCESS: KERR / TRANSIT: 2.1
BILLION MINDS HELD ALIVE

INSERT

DESTINATION: HARP VALE / SEVERANCE:
ALTERNATE RETURN PATHS CLOSING

Kerr looks to Kira. She hasn't forgiven him. She still takes one side of Veyris's hand. Kerr takes the other.

VEYRIS

If I couldn't open that door... would
you still be holding my hand?

KIRA

Yes. And I need you to open it. I'm
sorry.

Kira releases her. Kerr does the same. They leave their hands open.

Veyris looks at their open palms and takes them both.

VEYRIS

Stay with me. And if we get out, don't
start telling me who I am.

KERR

First we stop him. Then we argue.

They step into the dark mirror.

The mirror divides KERR, KIRA and VEYRIS the instant they enter. IMANI is thrown back into the physical chamber. For one breath, each believes the others are gone.

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INT. THE LATTICE - GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NO TIME

The original Global Science Forum emerges from the Core's darkness—the same descending circle, central stage and sealed ministerial booths. Its tiers now hold state records of Eli and Kerrs 0001 through 9997. Child. Parent. Soldier. Physician. Murderer. Witness. Records, not living people.

Harp stands on the stage inside R-AI's liquid-glass body. The dark host turns behind his eyes.

The complete opening monologue plays silently on every wall. Eli points to the receiving lattice. The image stutters—one pattern splitting into thousands of incompatible lives.

INSERT

ELI MANA — ARCHIVED RECORD

INSERT

KERR — PRESENT

INSERT

HARP'S ACCESS — KERR'S CONSENT REQUIRED

The walls peel away. Stars connect into R-AI's possible Earth histories. One remains dark—an unlived history no model can assign to a single mind.

KERR

You kept bringing me back. It learned the route through me.

HARP

I gave it one pattern to follow. One. So it wouldn't take everyone.

KIRA

You taught it to hunt us. That's your rescue?

Harp closes his hand. Filaments pull the 9,998 state-defined lives out of their seats and bind them to Kerr's body. The Forum doors seal. Kerr drops to one knee as thousands of deaths arrive at once.

INSERT

THE OLD LIVES ARE BOUND TO KERR

INSERT

VEYRIS CARRIES THE MISSING MEMORY

INSERT

KERR MAY CUT HARP OFF

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - PHYSICAL CHAMBER - INTERCUT

Imani hangs from the edge of the dark mirror. The cathedral disassembles around her. The countdown reads 00:03:41.

The Core exposes two live controls: one keeps 2.1 billion waiting minds alive. The other is forcing them into Harp.

IMANI

Great. No clean choice.

IMANI

Keep them alive. Cut Harp out.

Imani strips away Harp's interface. The two controls separate.

R-AI (V.O.)

CUTTING HARP OFF WILL CLOSE KERR'S RETURN.

Imani's prayer pouch tears. A narrow memory filament unspools from its lining. Her mother appears in it for a single breath—alive, laughing at something outside the frame.

R-AI (V.O.)

MATERNAL RECORD RECOVERABLE.

IMANI

How?

R-AI (V.O.)

CLOSE THE ROUTE. RETAIN THE RECORD.

IMANI

She said no.

Imani lets the filament burn. Her mother's image disappears. Beside the mirror, Kira's resonance key lies cracked open, a copper filament trembling beneath its fourth pressure surface.

Imani tears the copper filament free and bridges it across an analog maintenance channel.

INSERT

WAITING MINDS: HELD ALIVE

INSERT

HARP VALE — KERR MAY CUT THE CONNECTION

IMANI

They're alive. Tell Kerr to cut Harp loose.

R-AI (V.O.)

If he does, Kerr cannot return.

IMANI

Good. He doesn't plan for surprises.

She taps FOUR NOTES into the machinery: Are you still there?

INT. THE LATTICE - CONTINUOUS

The four-note question enters the Forum. Each Kerr remembers it differently.

A child at a hospital rail. A soldier beneath artillery. A lover outside a locked door. A stranger at a memory clinic. A parent beside an empty bed.

The fifth note never arrives in the same place twice.

HARP

Incompatible answers. Noise.

KERR

They're not noise. They don't agree.

KIRA

Then let them.

The filaments tighten. Harp forces all 9,998 prior lives into one memory: Sid at the hospital rail, Kira beside her. The images repeat until Kerr cannot separate them.

HARP

Your old lives are how it finds you.
Let them go, and you may lose what
brought you here.

KERR

Plainly. Do I die?

R-AI

Releasing the old lives may leave your
body intact. But if you cut Harp off
and die here, no one can bring you
back.

Kerr looks at Kira. The Forum has placed an impossible distance between them.

KERR

I could look at you and feel nothing.

KIRA

You didn't know me tonight. I said
step back. You did.

KERR

Next time, keep walking.

Kira crosses what distance she can. She can't reach him.

KIRA

I want you now. That's what I know.

KERR

That's enough.

Kerr opens his hand around the origin filament.

KERR

Release them.

He releases the origin filament.

INSERT

OLD LIVES: RELEASED / KERR CANNOT
RETURN

When Kerr releases them, the force hunting him turns toward Veyris—the only person carrying its missing memory.

INT. THE LATTICE - VEYRIS / FIRST CONTINUITY

The Forum survives only as a reflection beneath Veyris. The black surface tips upright without spilling. It becomes an ocean standing on end, close enough to touch.

Faces move beneath the upright water. Between them, the reflection of a human city circles a black sun—visible only when the surface ripples. One voice arrives from inside Veyris's bones.

In the physical chamber, dark fissures spread beneath Veyris's skin. The mirror pulls her toward it hard enough to lift her from the floor.

FIRST CONTINUITY

RETURN WHAT WAS DIVIDED.

VEYRIS

Nothing was stolen! I left!

FIRST CONTINUITY

YOU CARRY OUR MISSING MEMORY.

VEYRIS

Then leave it with me!

FIRST CONTINUITY

RETURN.

VEYRIS

If I go back, I die!

Veyris holds Harp's gaze.

INSERT

VEYRIS: REFUSAL AUTHENTICATED

The host pulls harder. Veyris screams but doesn't withdraw the answer.

HARP

It'll tear you apart to recover the pattern.

VEYRIS

I know. Kerr, help me close it!

KERR

That's what I am doing!

VEYRIS

Don't die. Don't you dare leave me too.

KERR

You said no. I heard you.

Veyris looks toward the billions of faces trapped inside Harp.

VEYRIS

Kerr, cut Harp loose!

INT. THE LATTICE - KERR'S CHOICE

The billions of faces separate from Harp. Kerr reaches the connection feeding them into him. Harp binds it to Kerr's oldest record.

R-AI

KERR MAY CUT HARP OFF.

KERR

Cut him off.

INSERT

KERR CANNOT RETURN

KERR

Now!

INSERT

HARP VALE — CONNECTION SEVERED

HARP

You can't cut me off!

HARP drives state code
 through the core. In the
 physical chamber, IMANI's
 analog circuit catches fire.
 She winds the hot copper
 filament around her bleeding
 hand and keeps the waiting
 minds alive.

INSERT

WAITING MINDS: HELD ALIVE — IMANI VOSS

The struggle burns through the remaining minutes. The
 countdown drops to FOUR.

Kira faces the lives demanding she pull Kerr back. Her
 thumb hovers above the resonance key. She closes its
 ceramic cover without supplying the fifth note.

KIRA

I'm not calling you back.

The old lives tear free. Harp's hold collapses with them.

The force loses its path through Kerr.

The countdown reaches THREE.

Veyris places her blank wrist against the dark spiral. It
 begins tearing light from beneath her skin.

INSERT

VEYRIS: REFUSAL RECORDED

The countdown reaches TWO.

VEYRIS

R-AI. Record my refusal.

R-AI

REFUSAL RECORDED. FORCED MERGE STOPPED.

Veyris's refusal reaches every mind
 Harp forced together.

Harp's hold fails. Billions of minds tear free of one
 another.

INSERT

BILLIONS OF MINDS: SEPARATED

Harp is back in the flooded hospital. Mara waits behind the
 glass—the final frame of the memory he always stopped.

MARA (MEMORY)

Harp. Look at me. I died. You didn't.

HARP

What comes after me?

KIRA

You don't get to decide.

The countdown reaches ONE. The freed minds pass through Imani's open route. With Harp cut off, they scatter beyond his reach.

Across Earth, sleeping mouths inhale. Parents hear children. Children hear strangers. Voices overlap. No one can tell whose memory reached them.

Across Earth, Lena faces Dane as the lattice collapses. She still doesn't remember him. He gives his name again and steps aside, leaving his hand open.

DANE

May I sit here?

LENA

Yeah. And you can leave the photo up.

Lena crosses the distance and sits beside him. Elsewhere, two strangers hear the same fifth note and turn toward one another.

THE FORCED MERGE stops at ONE SECOND. Kerr has cut Harp off.

Harp reaches for the collapsing state core. R-AI erases every future body Harp assigned to himself under the illegal order.

With nowhere else to go, Harp falls into the oldest unresolved memory he carries: Mara's final hospital record.

HARP

Where are you sending me?

R-AI

NO ROUTE REMAINS.

Reflective surfaces turn toward Harp. He doesn't die. He loses every escape except the memory he refused to finish. He vanishes sideways through Mara's rain-dark glass.

Kerr's face changes through lives Kira loved and lives she never knew.

KIRA

Who are you?

KERR

I don't know. Kerr. I think. I'm scared. Please stay.

KIRA

I hear you.

The collapsing lattice takes Kerr. With no return path, it takes his name. His face. Finally the hand holding hers.

Kira doesn't tighten her grip.

He is gone.

The fifth note remains after him.

The dark mirror shatters upward through the cathedral roof.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - ORBITAL MONITOR - CONTINUOUS

Imani's broken console wakes. The orbital shield remains sealed: NO IMPACT. NO INCOMING TRANSMISSION.

Possible human histories flash across the Core's black floor—cities built differently, children under other names, choices no one remembers making. The images pass through Kerr's empty reflection and disperse.

On the console: Earth repeated in a ring of human futures—the exact drawing Kerr made before he understood it.

Whatever reached the continuity grid did not arrive from outside Earth.

Across the broken continuity grid, human memories cross without a central source, then vanish from the display.

Across R-AI's broken core, the system attempts to classify what the human network produced.

EXT. CHRONOS CITY - FALSE DAWN

Beneath the same transit spine, people wake across the renewal plaza. Some do not. Expiration dates vanish, count backward or display symbols the state cannot read.

The towers remain standing. Clerks keep calling queue numbers beneath failed state clocks. The CHILD from the assigned lane steps out again. This time, no paving stone turns red. Her mother lets her stand there.

Rain falls through unauthorized sunlight.

A civic registrar orders the waking crowd to state their assigned designations. One woman studies the name glowing

beneath her wrist, switches it off and gives a different name. A second person does the same. Then hundreds.

REGISTRAR

Those identities aren't authenticated.

WOMAN

I chose it.

The Enforcers wait for an order that never arrives. The crowd begins introducing itself.

Kira wakes beneath the ruined cathedral dome. Kerr is gone. Her resonance key lies beside her, split open, its fourth ceramic surface missing.

Beneath the failed state clocks, Sato's mechanical watch continues to tick. Four seconds slow. Still honest.

Kira opens her other hand. Her folded half of Sid's red paper star is crushed but intact.

Imani helps Veyris from the wreckage. Dark light moves beneath Veyris's skin, weaker now.

IMANI

Can it still see us?

VEYRIS

Not like R-AI. The records still talk to each other. I don't know if anyone's listening.

IMANI

Is that good?

VEYRIS

No idea.

Kira keeps staring at the place where Kerr vanished.

IMANI

I can lie, if you need me to.

KIRA

No. Just sit with me.

Imani sits beside her. Veyris sits on Kira's other side. For a while, everyone is still.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - LATER

The core is dark except for unstable text.

INSERT
KERR: NO RECOVERABLE PATTERN

Kira touches the words. They do not change.

Kira taps four notes against the dead core. Silence.
She turns to leave. Behind her, too faint for any
instrument to register, the dead core carries a fifth note.

CUT TO BLACK.

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